

Question 18 · Unit 1 · 8 Marks

State any two reasons why an HRD professional needs to understand organisational culture.

Introduction

Culture is the context of all HRD work. Two main reasons: fit of interventions, and realistic change. Expand each and add supporting reasons for 8 marks.

Detailed points

- 1. Reason 1 — To design interventions that fit.** Appraisal, 360-degree feedback, outdoor training or open confrontation workshops can succeed or fail depending on values of hierarchy, face-saving, and power. A culture-blind copy of a foreign tool creates resistance. Understanding culture is professional competence, not extra knowledge.
- 2. Example for reason 1.** In a highly hierarchical culture, sudden public peer feedback may be seen as insult. The professional may start with private coaching and boss-supported feedback first.
- 3. Reason 2 — To read climate and change realistically.** Climate survey scores must be interpreted against culture. 'Low openness' in a military-like culture means something different from the same score in a start-up. Culture knowledge tells what can change this year and what needs a longer journey.
- 4. Communication and legitimacy.** Messages about development must use the organisation's language, stories and respected persons. Culture tells who must sponsor HRD (owner, union, professional CEO) for it to be legitimate.
- 5. Power and subcultures.** Functions, regions and generations may have subcultures. One-size HRD harms inclusion. Understanding culture includes understanding these pockets.
- 6. Strategy and desired culture.** If strategy needs innovation, HRD must know whether present culture punishes mistakes. Gap analysis between present and desired culture guides development of new behaviours.
- 7. Ethics.** Imposing a culture by force through HRD tools can harm people. Understanding existing culture is also respect.
- 8. Exam close.** Two reasons: (1) fit and acceptability of HRD tools; (2) diagnosis and paced culture change. Then mention communication, power, strategy.

Conclusion. *HRD without culture knowledge is technically neat and socially blind. That is why the professional must understand culture.*